Podcasting and Audio

12 ways to improve your show

Adapted for podcasts from recording, editing, and interviewing best-practice guides

Audio is the most forgiving medium in production and the least forgiving in quality: listeners tolerate mediocre content longer than they tolerate bad sound. Fix the room and the mic first, then the structure, then the polish.

Recording

- **1. Record in a soft, quiet room.** Rugs, curtains, and closets full of clothes absorb echoes; hard reflective rooms are the top audio killer.
- **2. Mic 4-6 inches away, slightly off-axis.** Angle the mic 15-30 degrees off-center and add a pop filter to tame plosives.
- **3. Always wear headphones.** They prevent remote-guest echo and let you catch plosives and breath noise live.
- **4. Record separate tracks per speaker.** The decision pays for itself the first time you edit a crossover conversation.
- **5. Mute yourself when others speak.** 'Mm-hmm' interruptions are annoying to hear and miserable to edit out.
- **6. Record a test clip first.** Thirty seconds of playback beats an hour of unfixable noise.

Structure

- **7. Cold-open with the best moment.** Preview the strongest 15-30 seconds before the intro.
- **8. Keep the intro under 60 seconds.** Branding, host name, and topic framing - then get out of the way.
- **9. Re-order for narrative, not chronology.** Move the strongest answer earlier; the conversation doesn't have to play in recorded order.
- **10. Ask open-ended, researched questions.** Study the guest's work; ask for stories, not yes/no answers.

Editing

- **11. Content edit before technical processing.** Tighten structure first - EQ on audio you're about to cut is wasted work.
- **12. Trim the runway before good answers.** Cut dead starts and framing that buries the question; target -16 LUFS for stereo.

Sources

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